Physics II — All Key Definitions

Phy 4143 · Lecture 1–4 · Quick-reference, 2-page version

Basic Quantities

Voltage: Electrical potential difference between two points in a circuit; the force that drives current. Measured in volts (V).

Current: The flow of electric charge (electrons) through a conductor. Measured in amperes (A).

Resistance: How much a material blocks the flow of current. Measured in ohms.

Ohm's Law: V = I x R — voltage is directly proportional to current and inversely proportional to resistance.

Circuit Fundamentals & Laws

Electric Circuit: A closed path for transmitting current through electrical and magnetic fields.

KCL (Kirchhoff's Current Law): The algebraic sum of currents at any node/junction is zero — current in = current out.

KVL (Kirchhoff's Voltage Law): The algebraic sum of voltages around any closed loop is zero.

Node, Junction, Branch, Loop, Mesh

Node: A point where two or more circuit elements are joined.

Junction: A point where three or more circuit elements meet; current divides here — this is where KCL applies.

Branch: The part of a network that lies between two junction points.

Loop: Any closed path in a network.

Mesh: The smallest loop that cannot be divided further.

Sources

Source: A device that converts mechanical, chemical or thermal energy into electrical energy; an active network element.

Voltage Source: A two-terminal device whose voltage is constant and independent of the current drawn from it (ideal: zero internal resistance).

Current Source: A two-terminal device that supplies the same current regardless of load voltage (ideal: infinite internal resistance).

Energy-Storing Elements

Inductor: A coil that stores energy in a magnetic field when current flows through it. v = L x (di/dt). Measured in henries (H).

Capacitor: Two conductive plates that store energy in an electric field. i = C x (dv/dt). Measured in farads (F).

Resistor Connections & Dividers

Series Connection: Resistors are in series when the same current flows through all of them. Req = R1 + R2 + ...

Parallel Connection: Resistors are in parallel when they share the same two nodes, so the same voltage appears across all of them.

Voltage Divider: v_R2 = [R2 / (R1+R2+R3)] x Vs — splits total voltage among series resistors, proportional to resistance.

Current Divider: i_R2 = [(1/R2) / (1/R1+1/R2+1/R3)] x Is — splits total current among parallel resistors.

Transformations

Source Transformation: A practical voltage source (V, series R) can be replaced by an equivalent current source (I=V/R, R in parallel), and vice versa.

Y-Delta / Delta-Y Transformation: Converts a 3-terminal Y (star) resistor network into an equivalent Delta (triangle) network, or vice versa.